

Which podcast genres perform best in India?

Dhruvank: There isn't just one genre that defines the Indian podcast audience today. What we're seeing is a much broader and more diverse listening ecosystem. One area where we've seen particularly strong interest is Knowledge & Learning. This includes people looking to upskill both personally and professionally, with significant interest in topics such as the startup ecosystem, personal finance, AI, business and learning from popular entrepreneurs, business leaders and athletes. At the same time, entertainment remains a very important part of podcast consumption, particularly among younger audiences who turn to podcasts for comedy, true crime, horror and pop culture alongside more serious subject matter. So, rather than pointing to one genre as the winner, I'd say the defining characteristic of India's podcast audience is breadth.

Which metrics best indicate a podcast's real health?

Dhruvank: Reach is important, but it is only the beginning of the story. The stronger indication of a podcast's health is whether people come back – whether a show is creating repeat listening, sustained engagement and ultimately a community of fans. Besides that, completion rate matters as well. Are people listening to 75%, 80% of an episode, or dropping off in the first five minutes? And then there are other high-intent signals, such as saves and shares, which can indicate that listeners are actively engaging with and returning to the content. We recently overhauled our creator analytics precisely because we wanted to give podcasters a clearer picture of this.

Can independent Indian podcasters monetise sustainably today?

Dhruvank: India's podcast audience is one of the largest in the world, yet it remains somewhat untapped from a monetisation standpoint. That gap

exists because the infrastructure simply hasn't caught up to the audience yet. Measurement standards, brand-safe environments, and contextual ad targeting are all still maturing. But I'd push back on framing this as a podcast problem. It's actually a category-wide signal that the monetisation moment is still ahead of us. Spotify is actively building those pipes.

With the launch of Spotify Ads Manager in India, we've made programmatic, self-serve audio advertising genuinely accessible to Indian brands for the first time at scale. It removes the friction between an advertiser wanting to reach a podcast audience and actually doing it. There's also a trust dimension to this. The monetisation gap in Indian podcasting is partly a trust gap. Brands need confidence that their spend is working.

Globally, Spotify has contributed more than \$10 billion to the podcast industry over the past five years through creator monetisation, audience scale, and the infrastructure that helps creators run their businesses. That's the long-term commitment that turns audience size into actual income for creators – and it's the same commitment we're bringing to India.

What prevents more Indian advertisers from investing in podcasts?

Dhruvank: The challenge is increasingly one of familiarity and infrastructure rather than audience. Advertisers have spent decades building planning, measurement and buying frameworks around television, digital video and display, while podcasting has had a shorter history within those systems. That means there can still be hesitation around how to measure the medium, compare it with other channels and demonstrate business impact. Audio is the second most attentive media environment in India, behind only cinema. That's not a reach story. That's an impact story. And the brands that understand this are seeing the results.

The industry is now addressing that gap. Spotify's launch of Ads Manager in India is designed to make audio advertising more accessible to brands, while audience data and measurement integrations can help advertisers move beyond basic demographic targeting towards behaviour, context and intent. The more measurable and accessible the medium becomes, the easier it is for podcast investment to become part of mainstream media planning.

What should a new podcaster do to grow on Spotify?

Dhruvank: I wouldn't optimize for virality. A viral episode can give you reach; a recognisable voice gives you longevity. The most useful question for a new creator isn't, "How do I get a million listeners?" It's, "Who is the audience I want to come back to, and why would they?" If you can answer that clearly, the rest of the growth strategy becomes much easier to build. From there, the fundamentals matter. Show up consistently, make your content genuinely discoverable, and pay attention to what your audience is telling you. Your show title, episode titles and descriptions are part of discovery too; they should make it immediately clear what the listener is going to get from you. I would also think about how your content can travel across formats.

Video can help create a stronger connection with an audience and give listeners more ways to discover a show, while audio remains essential because it allows podcasts to become part of everyday life. The goal isn't to be everywhere; it's to make the experience of discovering you lead naturally to becoming a regular listener. And finally, use the tools available to you. Features such as Previews and Prompted Playlists can create additional discovery pathways for emerging shows. But tools can amplify a good idea; they can't replace one. The core of success lies with voices that have something distinctive to say, show up consistently and give listeners a reason to come back. ■